



It's impossible to know in advance **how you will experience** the pain of labor, and certainly levels of pain **can vary greatly** between women. Your approach to labor, though, can have a big impact on how you fare: being informed about labor and what can help with the pain will **reduce tension and fear**; that in itself, will help you cope.

Pain relief in labor

Your experience of pain

The pain of labor is different from almost all other types of pain you will ever experience. Unlike pain that acts as a warning sign that something is amiss and you should stop what you're doing, labor pain is a sign that something is very right: your baby is about to be born.

The levels of pain, or perceptions of pain, women report in labor vary greatly. Some experience only moderate discomfort through much of labor, while for others the pain feels overwhelming. The nature of the pain, though, is characteristic of different stages of labor. The cramping feeling in the first stage occurs as the uterus contracts to push the baby into the pelvis. It's widespread and longlasting: you'll feel it in your abdomen, perhaps in your lower back, and sometimes even through your buttocks and down your thighs. In the second stage, pain is more localized as the muscles and tissues of the birth canal are stretched as your baby makes her way through the vagina.

The psychology of pain

Many women worry that they won't be able to deal with the pain of labor, and that if they need medical pain relief they will somehow have "failed" in this rite of passage. Studies show that women are able to manage better if they are informed about labor pain, which helps them feel

more empowered and relaxed. Understanding where labor pain comes from, exploring the options for pain relief, and making decisions about which forms you would like to have and which, if any, you would rather avoid are all important ways to take control of your labor. And in itself, feeling in control of what's happening and the choices you're making will help you deal with labor pain. Modern methods of pain relief don't harm your baby; the fear of pain, on the other hand, can make birth traumatic, not just for you, but for your baby, too. Thinking about labor pain as "positive" pain that helps you achieve something incredible can motivate you to prepare for this event, just as you would for, say, running a marathon.

Types of pain relief

Pain relief during labor is either natural or medical. Natural forms of pain relief (see p.228-29) include breathing and relaxation techniques and water births; and medical pain relief includes the use of certain opioid analgesics and some tranquilizers, as well as spinal blocks and epidurals. There is no right or wrong approach to pain relief in labor. If you start out thinking you'll be able to manage using breathing techniques alone, but then decide you need an epidural—ask for one. The most important thing is that your labor is as calm and as positive as possible.